Sheriff Manimbayan Abas

Sheriff Manimbayan Abas (born May 5, 1979) is a Filipino lawyer, election administrator, and regional politician from Cotabato City.

He served as Chairperson of the Commission on Elections (COMELEC) from November 2017 to February 2022, becoming the first Muslim Filipino, the first Mindanaoan, and the youngest person to hold that office in Philippine history.

He was also the first sitting COMELEC commissioner ever to be elevated to the chairpersonship, a distinction that set him apart not just as a symbolic milestone but as someone who already understood the commission's mechanics from the inside before leading it.

Among his most consequential acts in office was presiding over the 2019 Bangsamoro Autonomy Plebiscite, the historic popular vote that ratified Republic Act No. 11054 (the Bangsamoro Organic Law) and formally established the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM) in place of the old Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM).

Following his retirement from national service, Abas pivoted back to his home region. In 2026, he filed his Certificate of Candidacy for the 1st Parliamentary District of Cotabato City, running under the United Bangsamoro Justice Party (UBJP) in the inaugural Bangsamoro Parliamentary Elections.

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Sheriff Manimbayan Abas



Born

May 5, 1979

Cotabato City, Philippines

Ethnicity

Maguindanaoan

Religion

Islam

Nationality

Filipino

Occupation

Lawyer; election official; regional politician

Education

B.A. Philosophy, Notre Dame University (1999)

LL.B., Ateneo de Davao University (2004) Philippine Bar, 2005

Political Party

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United Bangsamoro Justice Party (UBJP)

Key Position

Chairperson, Commission on Elections (COMELEC)

November 22, 2017 – February 2, 2022

Appointed By

President Rodrigo R. Duterte (as Chairperson)

President Benigno S. Aquino III (as Commissioner)

Preceded By

Andres D. Bautista (as COMELEC Chair)

Succeeded By

Socorro B. Inting (acting)

Family Connection

Nephew of Mohagher Iqbal, MILF peace negotiator

NOTABILITY

First Muslim, first Mindanaoan, and youngest person to serve as COMELEC Chairperson of the Philippines; presided over the historic 2019 Bangsamoro Autonomy Plebiscite that established the BARMM.

KNOWN FOR

Breaking multiple institutional firsts at COMELEC; overseeing the Bangsamoro Organic Law plebiscites; election law expertise; candidacy for the inaugural Bangsamoro Parliament (2026).

EARLY LIFE AND BACKGROUND

Sheriff Manimbayan Abas was born on May 5, 1979, in Cotabato City, the beating heart of the Bangsamoro homeland in the Philippines.

He grew up in a family with deep roots in the Moro movement, which shaped his political and legal consciousness from early on.

His uncle is Mohagher Iqbal, one of the most consequential figures in the Bangsamoro peace process and longtime chief negotiator and Minister of Education of the Moro Islamic Liberation Front (MILF).

That family connection to the peace negotiations would later become a point of scrutiny when Abas rose to lead COMELEC, but it also speaks to the broader ecosystem of Bangsamoro public service that Abas came from: a world where law, governance, and community advocacy are deeply intertwined.

He completed his primary and secondary schooling in Mindanao before heading to higher education, first in Cotabato City and later in Davao.

EDUCATION

Abas built his academic foundation with a strong grounding in the humanities and the law, both of which would prove useful in a career that required sharp analytical thinking and the ability to communicate clearly with the public.

He earned a **Bachelor of Arts in Philosophy** from Notre Dame University in Cotabato City in 1999.

He then pursued his law degree at Ateneo de Davao University, completing his **Bachelor of Laws** (LL.B.) in 2004.

In 2005, he passed the **Philippine Bar Examination**, officially entering the legal profession.

The combination of philosophical training and legal education gave Abas a particular style: he tended to reason carefully and speak plainly, two traits that served him well both in the classroom and later in the glare of national media attention.

EARLY LEGAL AND GOVERNMENT CAREER

Before his name became associated with national elections, Abas quietly built a reputation as a legal officer and public servant in Muslim Mindanao.

He worked as a **law professor**, sharing what he had learned in Davao with the next generation of Bangsamoro lawyers.

In government, he devoted eight years to the Civil Service Commission (CSC), the agency that manages the professional standards and conduct of Philippine bureaucrats.

From June 2007 to April 2015, Abas served the CSC's regional office for the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM), rising through the ranks from legal officer to **Acting Assistant Regional Director**.

That role, unglamorous by most measures but deeply practical, gave Abas a ground-level understanding of how government systems actually work, or fail to work, in a region that had seen decades of underinvestment and conflict.

It was the kind of foundation that would make him a credible voice not just on election procedures but on governance more broadly.

COMMISSION ON ELECTIONS

Appointment as Commissioner (2015–2017)

On April 28, 2015, President Benigno S. Aquino III appointed Abas as a COMELEC commissioner to fill a vacancy created by the retirement of incumbent members.

He joined the commission alongside Chairperson Andres Bautista and Commissioner Rowena Guanzon, two figures who would each, in very different ways, leave their own marks on Philippine electoral history.

At 35 years old, Abas was already one of the youngest commissioners ever to sit on the poll body.

His first major test came in the **2016 national and local elections**.

Abas was designated head of the Packing and Shipping Committee, the team responsible for deploying the enormous logistics operation that a nationwide automated election demands.

Under his watch, the committee coordinated the deployment of over **92,000 vote-counting machines** (VCMs) and approximately **56 million official ballots** to precincts across the Philippine archipelago, from the mountain provinces of the Cordillera to the farthest islands of the Sulu Sea.

Senator Cynthia Villar, who sponsored his later confirmation as chairperson, would note that the 2016 elections were widely regarded as one of the most transparent and efficient in Philippine history, with 96 percent of precinct results reported within 12 hours, a record at the time.

Abas's role in that logistical success did not go unnoticed.

Promotion to Chairperson (2017–2022)

The path to the chairpersonship opened abruptly when Andres Bautista resigned on October 11, 2017, amid mounting personal and legal controversies involving allegations of hidden wealth.

President Rodrigo R. Duterte designated Abas as the new COMELEC Chairperson on **November 22, 2017**.

The appointment was not without controversy.

Critics pointed to Abas's kinship with Mohagher Iqbal of the MILF, raising questions about potential conflicts of interest at a time when the commission was preparing to administer plebiscites on the Bangsamoro Basic Law (BBL) and the proposed Bangsamoro political entity.

Abas addressed this directly and formally: he **inhibited himself** from all official proceedings related to the Bangsamoro Basic Law, removing himself entirely from deliberations where his family ties could create even the appearance of partiality.

The Commission on Appointments (CA) officially confirmed his appointment on **May 23, 2018**.

At 38 years old, Abas had broken a set of institutional records that had stood for the poll body's entire history:

- First chairperson from Mindanao
- First Muslim Filipino to lead the commission
- First sitting commissioner promoted to the chairpersonship
- Youngest chairperson in COMELEC history

His term was set to run until **February 2, 2022**, the end of his original seven-year constitutional appointment.

KEY ELECTIONS AND MILESTONES

2018 Barangay and Sangguniang Kabataan Elections

Among the first tests of Abas's leadership were the **2018 Philippine barangay and Sangguniang Kabataan elections**, which involved coordinating localized polling across tens of thousands of barangays and engaging the youth electorate through the Sangguniang Kabataan (SK) electoral process.

The elections provided early proof that Abas could manage the operational complexity of nationwide polling while keeping the commission's credibility intact.

2019 Bangsamoro Autonomy Plebiscite

The most historically significant exercise of Abas's tenure was his oversight of the **2019 Bangsamoro autonomy plebiscite**.

Held in January and February 2019, the plebiscite asked voters in Muslim Mindanao to ratify Republic Act No. 11054, more commonly known as the Bangsamoro Organic Law (BOL).

The affirmative vote formally established the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM) and replaced the long-troubled ARMM, which had existed since 1989 but had never quite delivered the degree of genuine self-governance it promised.

The plebiscite was the culmination of decades of peace negotiations, including those led by Abas's own uncle Mohagher Iqbal, and its successful administration under a Bangsamoro Muslim chairperson carried its own symbolic weight.

Abas's inhibition from the BBL proceedings had, by this point, helped insulate the commission from accusations of bias, and the plebiscite proceeded without major procedural challenge to its integrity.

2019 Midterm General Elections

The **2019 midterm elections** were the other major national test during Abas's tenure.

The automated election system registered a **72 percent voter turnout**, a strong showing by Philippine standards.

There were isolated technical problems: some vote-counting machines (VCMs) experienced glitches, and a number of secure digital (SD) cards had to be replaced at affected precincts.

But Abas was quick to note what did not happen: there were **zero nationwide election failures**, and the winning candidates in most races were proclaimed with a speed that had rarely been seen in previous election cycles.

The 2019 midterms also demonstrated COMELEC's capacity to handle both national and local elections simultaneously at scale, without systemic collapse.

Retirement and End of Tenure

Abas completed his full constitutional term and **retired from COMELEC on February 2, 2022**, just months before the May 2022 presidential election that brought Ferdinand Marcos Jr. to the presidency.

He stepped down alongside veteran commissioners Rowena Guanzon and Antonio Kho Jr., who also concluded their tenures on the same date.

His successor as acting chair was Socorro B. Inting.

POST-COMELEC CAREER

Abas Law Firm

Following his retirement from government service, Abas returned to private practice and established the **Abas Law Firm**, a legal practice specializing in election law advisory and litigation.

Given his seven years at the helm of the Philippines' electoral body, his expertise in election law was, by this point, arguably unmatched in the country.

The firm positioned itself to advise on the increasingly complex intersection of election administration, political party law, and the evolving legal landscape of the BARMM.

Bangsamoro Parliamentary Politics

In late 2024, Abas made a public pivot back to regional governance.

With the Bangsamoro Parliament's inaugural elections drawing near, he formalized his intent to run for a seat representing the **1st Parliamentary District of Cotabato City** under the **United Bangsamoro Justice Party** (UBJP), the political arm of the MILF and the dominant force within the interim Bangsamoro Transition Authority (BTA).

His initial Certificate of Candidacy filing in November 2024 came at a moment of considerable uncertainty: the Supreme Court had recently ruled to exclude Sulu province from the BARMM, which necessitated legislative and administrative adjustments to the electoral framework.

Congressional bills were filed in late 2024 to defer the elections, and Abas acknowledged at the time that the timing was uncertain, with roughly equal odds that the elections would proceed as scheduled or be pushed back.

Ultimately, under **Republic Act No. 12317**, signed into law by President Ferdinand Marcos Jr. on March 25, 2026, the first regular Bangsamoro Parliamentary Elections were officially rescheduled to **September 14, 2026**.

Abas filed his finalized Certificate of Candidacy on **May 6, 2026**, joining other UBJP candidates including Mansoor Ebrahim, son of MILF Chairman Ahod "Al Haj Murad" Ebrahim.

If elected, Abas would make history once more: he would become the **first former COMELEC chairperson to serve as a member of the Bangsamoro Parliament**.

In his own words, shared with reporters at the time of his initial filing, the motivation was straightforward: after years of serving the national government, he wanted to bring that experience home to serve his own community directly.

LEGACY AND SIGNIFICANCE

The record Abas built at COMELEC is, in many ways, a Bangsamoro story embedded inside a national institution.

His appointment and confirmation broke barriers that had stood since the poll body's founding, not through confrontation, but through competence and careful navigation of an institution that had never before been led by someone from Muslim Mindanao.

His handling of the 2019 plebiscite, the democratic exercise that gave the Bangsamoro people a formal political home, remains the most symbolically resonant chapter of his public career.

The fact that it was administered cleanly, under a Muslim chairperson who voluntarily stepped aside from related proceedings to preserve impartiality, is a point of pride for Bangsamoro advocates of democratic governance.

His return to regional politics in 2026 represents a third act: not just a former official seeking a new platform, but a person with deep technical knowledge of how elections work choosing to put that knowledge in the service of the very community whose rights he spent years protecting from the other side of the ballot.

SEE ALSO

- Commission on Elections (Philippines)
- Bangsamoro Organic Law
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Moro Islamic Liberation Front
- Mohagher Iqbal
- United Bangsamoro Justice Party

- Bangsamoro Transition Authority
- 2019 Bangsamoro autonomy plebiscite

EXTERNAL LINKS

- Rappler: Ex-COMELEC Chairman Abas seeks Cotabato seat in BARMM Parliament (https://www.rappler.com/philippines/mindanao/ex-comelec-chairman-sheriff-abas-seeks-cotabato-seat-barmm-parliament/)
- Tribune: Ex-COMELEC Chair Files COC for District Representative (https://tribune.net.ph/2024/11/06/ex-comelec-chair-files-coc-for-district-representative)
- Manila Times: Former COMELEC Chairman Abas Files COC for Parliament (https://www.manilatimes.net/2026/05/06/regions/former-comelec-chairman-abas-files-coc-for-parliament/2336843)

Reference Note

This post is shared for cultural, educational, and documentary purposes. This is not an official record but part of an ongoing effort to document and preserve Bangsamoro history and heritage. Details may be updated as additional sources become available.

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